NUTRILISH

Cutting vs Bulking

The Complete Nutrition Guide

Everything you need to know about eating for your physique goals.

Science-Based • Practical • Free

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1 Understanding The Basics

THE TWO PHASES

🔥 CUTTING

GOAL	Lose fat, preserve muscle
CALORIES	-300 to -500 below TDEE
DURATION	8–16 weeks
RATE	0.5–1% body weight / week
RISK	Muscle loss if too aggressive

💪 BULKING

GOAL	Build muscle, minimize fat gain
CALORIES	+200 to +400 above TDEE
DURATION	12–24 weeks
RATE	0.25–0.5% body weight / week
RISK	Excess fat if surplus too large

When to Cut vs Bulk

Body fat > 20% (men) / > 30% (women)	→ CUT FIRST
Body fat 12–20% (men) / 20–30% (women)	→ EITHER
Body fat < 12% (men) / < 20% (women)	→ BULK
New to lifting? Newbie gains window (first 3–6 months)	→ RECOMP

PRO TIP

Don't bulk above 20% body fat or cut below 10%. Cycling between 12–18% body fat is the sweet spot for most men — you stay lean enough to look good while building meaningful muscle.

2 Cutting Protocol

🔥

THE CUTTING BLUEPRINT

Cutting macros for a 180 lb person. Protein goes **UP** during a cut (1–1.2g per lb body weight) — it's your primary defense against muscle loss.

2,100	175g	174g	62g
CALORIES (DEFICIT)	PROTEIN	CARBS	FAT

CUTTING DAY SAMPLE — 180 LB PERSON

BREAKFAST	🥚 Egg white omelette + whole egg + spinach + 2 toast	420 cal · 38P · 32C · 14F
LUNCH	🍗 Chicken breast + rice + huge salad + light dressing	520 cal · 45P · 44C · 14F
PRE-WORKOUT	🍌 Protein shake + banana + almond butter	380 cal · 32P · 40C · 12F
DINNER	🐟 Salmon + sweet potato + asparagus	480 cal · 36P · 40C · 18F
SNACK	🧀 Cottage cheese + berries	200 cal · 24P · 18C · 4F

Total: 2,000 cal P: 175g C: 174g F: 62g

Cutting Tips

- Protein at every meal — minimum 30g per sitting to maximize muscle protein synthesis
- High-volume, low-calorie foods: leafy greens, cucumbers, egg whites, broth-based soups
- Stay hydrated — 1 gallon per day minimum. Thirst masks hunger.
- Sleep 7–9 hours. Cortisol destroys muscle and spikes appetite when you're under-recovered.
- Refeed days: 1x per week at maintenance calories with extra carbs to reset leptin
- Cardio: 2–3x per week, low-intensity (walking, cycling) to preserve muscle glycogen

- Track everything — "eyeballing" leads to 300–500 hidden calories per day

3 Bulking Protocol

💪

THE BULKING BLUEPRINT

Bulking macros for a 180 lb person. Carbs go **UP** during a bulk — they fuel training intensity and accelerate recovery between sessions.

2,900	180g	330g	90g
CALORIES (SURPLUS)	PROTEIN	CARBS	FAT

BULKING DAY SAMPLE — 180 LB PERSON

BREAKFAST	🌾 Protein oats + banana + PB + whole milk	650 cal · 38P · 72C · 22F
LUNCH	🌯 Double chicken burrito bowl + rice + beans + cheese	720 cal · 52P · 68C · 24F
PRE-WORKOUT	🥯 Bagel + honey + protein shake	480 cal · 30P · 72C · 8F
DINNER	🥩 Lean beef stir-fry + white rice + veggies	680 cal · 44P · 70C · 22F
SNACK	🥜 Trail mix + protein bar	440 cal · 24P · 48C · 18F

Total: 2,970 cal P: 188g C: 330g F: 94g

Bulking Tips

- Progressive overload in the gym is NON-NEGOTIABLE — a surplus without training stimulus builds fat, not muscle
- Eat calorie-dense foods: nuts, oils, whole milk, white rice, oats — volume is your enemy here
- Protein: 0.8–1g per lb is sufficient during a bulk — save the extra calories for carbs
- Load carbs around workouts: big meal pre-workout, fast carbs post-workout
- Don't skip meals — consistency matters more than any single perfect day
- Aim for "clean bulk": 80% whole foods, 20% flexible. Dirty bulks add fat, not muscle.

- If gaining more than 1% body weight per week, dial back the surplus — you're adding fat

4 Head-to-Head Comparison

FACTOR	🔥 CUTTING	💪 BULKING
CALORIES	Deficit (-300 to -500)	Surplus (+200 to +400)
PROTEIN	1–1.2g per lb	0.8–1g per lb
CARBS	Moderate–Low	High
FAT	Low–Moderate	Moderate
CARDIO	2–3x/week recommended	Optional
TRAINING VOLUME	Maintain or slight decrease	Progressive overload
DURATION	8–16 weeks	12–24 weeks
RATE OF CHANGE	0.5–1% BW/week	0.25–0.5% BW/week
PRIORITY	Preserve muscle, lose fat	Build muscle, limit fat
MEAL FREQUENCY	4–5 meals (appetite control)	4–6 meals (calorie density)

SUPPLEMENT ESSENTIALS

Creatine Monohydrate

5G DAILY • YEAR-ROUND

Most researched supplement in history. Boosts strength and performance in both phases.

Whey Protein

1–2 SCOOPS DAILY

Convenient protein source. Use it to close the gap on daily protein targets.

Vitamin D3

2,000–5,000 IU DAILY

Most people are deficient. Supports testosterone, immunity, and recovery.

Omega-3 Fish Oil

1–2G EPA+DHA DAILY

Anti-inflammatory. Supports heart health, brain function, and joint recovery.

Caffeine

100–200MG PRE-WORKOUT

Improves strength output and endurance. Especially useful during a cut for energy.

Magnesium

200–400MG BEFORE BED

Improves sleep quality and recovery. Most people are chronically deficient.

PRO TIP

Supplements are the last 5%. Nail your calories, protein, sleep, and training first. No pill replaces consistency — but the right ones make consistency easier.

5 Your 12-Month Plan

SAMPLE YEAR OVERVIEW

JAN – MAR (12 WEEKS)
BULK — Focus on building muscle and strength. Train heavy, eat big, prioritize compound lifts.

APRIL (4 WEEKS)
Maintenance — Eat at TDEE. Let your body normalize at the new weight before cutting.

MAY – JUL (12 WEEKS)
CUT — Lean out for summer. Slow deficit, high protein, 2–3x cardio per week.

AUGUST (4 WEEKS)
Maintenance — Stabilize your new body composition. Lock in the habits.

SEP – NOV (12 WEEKS)
BULK — Off-season gains. Leverage lower body fat for a more efficient bulk.

DECEMBER (4 WEEKS)
Maintenance — Enjoy the holidays. Eat at TDEE. Set up for a strong January.

QUICK DECISION FRAMEWORK

Ask yourself these 3 questions:

1. Am I above 18% body fat right now? — **Cut First**
2. Am I satisfied with my current muscle mass? — **If No, Bulk**
3. Is there a deadline — vacation, competition, event? — **Cut 12 Wks Out**

12–18% IDEAL BF RANGE TO CYCLE (MEN)	**~0.5 lb** OPTIMAL WEEKLY BULK GAIN
1g/lb PROTEIN TARGET WHILE CUTTING	**+300** CAL SURPLUS SWEET SPOT

Let NutriLish adapt your nutrition to every phase

AI-powered macro tracking that evolves with your goals. Cut or bulk — NutriLish has you covered.

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